year-old had not had a cup of milk in over a month and the family was exclusively relying on the free rice, wheat and pulses provided by the government as their meals in the absence of any money available to buy other groceries. Sometimes, the middlemen distributing the rice and pulses would cut corners and the grains would come in mixed with pebbles or sand even, and at other times, the middlemen would not come through with the grains at all. Desperation was at a peak. If at home, in the village, they would have no shortage of good food, farm-grown vegetables and meat and they would also be able to work in the fields and generate income out of farming.

Every day, there was a new rumour in the drain-lined lane housing their room about many people falling severely ill with the virus and being taken away by the government to quarantine centres. Sometimes those rumours would get serious when news would arrive that the person taken away had not been able to make it alive. Meena was worried about the baby's health and was willing to take any risk to be able to go back home.

Emotions were running high as this was the case in most rooms in the Nehru Nagar Chawl. In a tense situation like this, news came in via some boys in the chawl that the local police station had called and confirmed that the government had arranged for a train scheduled to depart for Bihar late in the afternoon to send folks like them back home.[5] Her husband rushed in and asked her to immediately pack the essentials and the baby and leave as soon as possible so as to make the long 45-minute walk to the Bandra Terminus Railway Station. They didn't have any further details of how many trains were arranged or the timings or the scheduled trains; and in the case with so many unknowns, they decided to follow the flock. Most migrants living in the chawl had also set off towards the Bandra Terminus Station. Hundreds of them rushed out of the chawl, outnumbering the lathi-yielding policemen who were stationed there and began to brisk walk. Most were not even carrying bags with them, which Meena found a little odd, even in the heat of the moment. She had managed to tie the baby's essentials and some water in a cloth which she carried over her shoulder. They made their way to the station by foot in the absence of any available public transport.

As they arrived at the station, they found that no such train was scheduled to depart for their home state and they had just fallen for a false rumour. Like Meena Mukhiya and her family, thousands of other people